# Self-Perceptions on Social Media vs. Offline Contrast With Those Perceived in Generalized but not Close Others

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## Author Note

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**Abstract**

Self-perception varies across contexts. Do perceptions of others across contexts vary in the same way? Here, a multi-study mapping of context-framed person perception addressed this question. Participants (*N* = 1749) reported perceptions of the Big Five personality traits specifying two contexts that dominate daily life (offline and social media) regarding three targets: self, the typical person (Studies 1-3, 5), and peers (Studies 4 and 5). The perceptions were examined both within-person via profile agreements and normatively via mean levels. Profile agreement analyses suggested that the similarity between offline and social media contexts was strong in self-perceptions (and perceptions of peers) but moderate in perceptions of the typical person. Mean level analyses further suggested generally lower trait levels on social media vs. offline in self-perceptions (and perceptions of peers). However, perceptions of the typical person showed the opposite or attenuated effects in terms of 3/5 traits (openness, extraversion, and neuroticism). Perceptions of all three targets showed lower levels of agreeableness on social media than offline. Conscientiousness was the only trait to show inconclusive patterns across the studies. Together, the findings suggest that self-perceptions on social media vs. offline contexts contrast with those perceived in generalized (but not close) others.

*Keywords*: Personality; self-perception; social perception; similarity; social media

**Plain Language Title:**

Do People Perceive Themselves and Other People as Similar on Social Media and Offline?

**Plain Language Summary**

People do not always think they are the exact same person across situations. Do people also think other people vary across situations in the same ways? The present research drew on personality theory to investigate this question. The focus was on how people perceive personality traits in themselves and in other people on social media versus offline. These two situational contexts are very different, and people spend a lot of time in both. Thus, the comparison may show informative differences in how people view themselves and others. There were five studies involving a total of 1,749 participants. In each study, participants reported the personality traits they thought described themselves offline and on social media. They also reported their perceptions of others on the same traits in both contexts. In some studies, participants reported perceptions of the typical person. In the other studies, participants reported perceptions of a peer. Based on the results, it turns out that people perceive themselves and their peers as having similar traits offline versus on social media. However, people perceive the typical person as more different between the two contexts. Another standout result indicated that people tend to perceive the typical person as much more extraverted on social media than offline. However, they tend to perceive the opposite in themselves and their peers. These findings suggest that people sometimes perceive themselves as having a different personality in some contexts. They perceive this in others too, but not necessarily in the same way. A broader implication is that people may perceive others across contexts in ways that do not align with self-perceptions. The research demonstrates how personality theory can inform our understanding of social perceptions derived

from social media use. This understanding is becoming increasingly important as people spend more and more time online.

## Self-Perceptions on Social Media vs. Offline Contrast With Those Perceived in Generalized but not Close Others

Individuals differ significantly in the degree to which they view themselves and others as similar (Kenny & West, 2010; Thielmann, Rau et al., 2023). Various terms referring to perceived similarity suggest different explanations (Hughes et al., 2021; Thielmann et al., 2020). Perceived similarity has been investigated, for example, as assumed similarity (Cronbach, 1955; Human & Biesanz, 2011; Kenny, 1994), attributive projection (Holmes, 1968; Sherwood, 1981), elicited similarity (Hughes et al., 2021), the false consensus effect (Krueger & Clement, 1994; Ross et al., 1977), self-anchoring (Cadinu & Rothbart, 1996; Otten & Wentura, 2001), the self-based heuristic (Ready et al., 2000; Weller & Watson, 2009), and social projection (Kruger, 2000). Perceived similarity is consequential. For example, perceived similarity can increase empathy towards a target (Cialdini et al., 1997) and enhance relationship satisfaction (Murray et al., 2002; Pancorbo et al., 2021). On the other hand, a lack of perceived similarity can lead to dehumanization or discrimination (Krueger, 2007).

A key unanswered question is whether perceived similarity depends on social contexts or if it is independent of context. Prior research on perceived similarity shares an assumption of trait theory that personality is stable across contexts (Allport & Odbert, 1936). This assumption is understandable given the focus on perceived similarity in terms of the Big Five personality traits, which are rooted in trait theory (Digman, 1990; Goldberg, 1990). However, personality expression varies across contexts (Fleeson, 2004; Mischel et al., 2002). Whole Trait Theory (Fleeson & Jayawickreme, 2015; Jayawickreme et al., 2019) suggests that researchers should take situational contexts into account when examining personality traits. The theory proposes that personality traits comprise both distributions of personality expression within contexts and social-cognitive reactions to the situational cues that underly them. Perceived similarity is often examined in a particular context, such as a laboratory round robin (Kenny & West, 2010), but not compared across contexts within perceivers. What is unclear, therefore, is whether people perceive personality expressions across contexts as the same between themselves and others.

Here, a multi-study mapping of context-framed person perception was conducted to address this question. The studies compared perception between two strikingly different contexts that dominate life today: the offline world and social media. People constantly switch between these two contexts. Over two-thirds of the global population is on social media, averaging over 2 hours daily (Chaffey, 2025; Petrosyan, 2024). Among other features that drastically alter the nature of social interaction, people can selectively choose how to present themselves on social media in ways that were historically impossible (Bayer et al., 2020; McFarland & Ployhart, 2015). Further, in the historically unfamiliar digital environment, the psychological distance between users and the targets of their perception has expanded beyond typical physical interactions (Robertson et al., 2024a). Users' social media feeds exaggerate expressive content from other people (Robertson et al., 2024b), but most people do not even post at all on social media (Bestvater, 2024; McClain et al., 2021). There may be resulting misalignments between how people perceive *themselves* on social media versus offline, compared to how they view *others* between the two contexts. Therefore, an offline and social media comparison is ideal to test whether situational context alters the way people think about what they share (or do not share) with other people. The present research primarily focused on whether perceived differences between offline and social media contexts varied when the target was the self vs. others (rather than whether perceived differences between the self and others varied when the context was offline vs. social media).

Moreover, a rising body of research has addressed self-perceptions and perceptions in the context of social media from which to build on. Findings from prior research have generated insights but are complicated by an array of a) targets (e.g., self, others), b) contexts (offline, social media), and c) analytic strategies (e.g., mean level differences, within-perceiver profile agreements). Lack of explicit comparison across these approaches blurs theoretical distinctions and undermines practical application to understanding person perception in an increasingly digital world. The present research sought to survey prior approaches to ground a rich descriptive test of whether context-framed self-perceptions vary from those perceived in others.

**Self and Social Perception Offline and on Social Media**

One line of prior research examined context-framed self-perceptions. A main finding is that people do not report the same level of Big Five personality traits when thinking about their social media versus offline selves (Bunker & Kwan, 2021). Further studies suggest that these context-framed differences generally hold across genders (Bunker et al., 2021), generations and platform preferences (Bunker & Kwan, 2024), and the past decade (cf., Blumer & Döring, 2012; Bunker & Kwan, 2024). Self-perceptions on social media predict subjective well-being and global self-perceptions (i.e., self-perceptions without a specified context) independently of offline self-perceptions (Bunker & Kwan, 2024; Bunker et al., 2024), suggesting that both offline and social media contexts inform how people see themselves. However, people's perceptions of others offline vs. on social media were not examined in this line of research.

A second line of research examined perceptions of others. A main finding is that perceivers' judgements of others' social media behavior correspond to those others' self-reported personality traits (Back et al., 2010; Human et al., 2021; Orehek & Human, 2017). However, perceptions of targets' social media behavior were compared to the targets' *global* self-reported traits (i.e., reports that did not specify situational context). Considering the findings in the first line of research on self-perceptions, the targets may have considered who they are on social media when reporting their traits without a specified context (i.e., a hidden frame of reference; Schulze et al., 2021; 2024). Accordingly, how people perceive the personality traits of others' offline and social media selves, and how they correspond to perceivers' self-perceptions, is unknown.

Prior research also used various analytic approaches to index perceived similarity. A central distinction is between trait-based (i.e., comparing individuals on a trait to other individuals on the same trait) and profile-based approaches (i.e., considering the profile of multiple traits for each individual; Back & Nestler, 2016). Using a trait-based approach, one study, for example, examined relationships between observer perceptions of targets' social media profiles and the targets' self-reports regarding each of the Big Five (e.g., Back et al., 2010). One of the other studies used a trait-based approach by examining how, on average, people view themselves offline vs. on social media for each Big Five trait (Bunker & Kwan, 2021). Other studies used a profile-based approach, which involves correlating two sets of personality trait ratings (Furr, 2008). One study, for example, examined tendencies to be perceived in line with one's unique traits (i.e., expressive accuracy) between offline and social media contexts through within-person profiles (Human et al., 2021). This same study also examined context-specified expressive accuracy ratings by high and low observability traits, suggesting that employing both profile-based and trait-based approaches can offer insight into overall vs. trait-specific effects (see also Thielmann, Rau et al., 2023).

The present research sought to combine insights from prior research lines by examining a) self-perceptions and perceptions of others in b) offline and social media contexts, and by examining c) within-perceiver profile agreements and trait-wise normative averages in these perceptions. The within-perceiver profile agreement analyses were suggested during the review process and thus exploratory. However, the present research tested an initial hypothesis regarding normative perceptions. Given the complexity involved in the novel test of multiple targets, contexts, and analytic approaches, there was not strong theory to formulate individual hypotheses regarding all of the individual Big Five traits or underlying mechanisms. Nevertheless, the present research drew on theories of situational context and prior observed patterns to suggest a general tendency in how context-framed perception (offline vs. social media) of the Big Five personality traits deviates between normative self-perception and perception of others. This initial hypothesis was an inductive generalization rather than a mechanism-derived prediction for each of the Big Five. That is, the hypothesis was intended to help interpret the presented descriptive mapping of context-framed person perception and provide the groundwork for future research to test mechanisms underlying the observed effects.

## Context-Framed Perceptions of the Self vs. Others

People filter situations into single coherent perceptual entities in lieu of processing every aspect of situations they encounter (Rauthmann, 2012). From this perspective, people likely form perceptions of the social media contexts they take part in and how they compare to the offline world. The DIAMONDS framework (Rauthmann et al., 2014) proposed specific dimensions of situation perception that offline and social media contexts are likely to differ on. The natures of social interaction (Sociality) or deceiving people (Deception), for example, are likely to distinguish person perception between offline and social media contexts.

First, consider how the unique situational context of social media may influence *perceptions of others*. Like the offline world, users form spontaneous judgments of others on social media (Levordashka & Utz, 2017). Such judgments reduce cognitive load and facilitate efficient social interaction (Sherman et al., 1998). However, features of social media platforms may tilt social judgment. Social media algorithms are designed to exploit social biases to keep users engaged (Brady et al., 2023a). Specifically, users compete for attention and algorithms that spread content, but only a minority of very active users are likely to achieve popularity (Fisher, 2022; Van Bavel et al., 2024). The most active users, and thus the ones likely to populate social media feeds, tend to present themselves as more attractive and successful than they are (van Dijck, 2013; Yau & Reich, 2019) and post expressive views (Bail, 2022; Barberá & Rivero, 2015). Digital attention algorithms thus seem to favor expressive individuals who do not behave like most people on social media but are nevertheless the most likely to be seen on social media (Robertson et al., 2024b). Such skewed content exposure on social media may lead people to perceive others as more expressive than they really are on social media, perhaps more so than in offline life. This reasoning is consistent with the availability heuristic in which people make inferences based on what is available to them (Tversky & Kahneman, 1973).

At the same time, other work suggests that, in contrast, people are likely to *perceive themselves* as less expressive on social media compared to offline contexts. A recent review suggested that digital environments like social media platforms actually constrain the self for most people (Talaifar & Lowery, 2023). For example, social media algorithms reduce personal choice needed for self-expression by reinforcing people to be more like past selves or normative averages. The majority of people also censor their own behavior on social media due to perceived audiences (Das & Kramer, 2013), which tend to be much larger compared to offline contexts (McFarland & Ployhart, 2015). Such self-censorship has been dubbed the “chilling effect” of social media (Marder et al., 2016), and evidence for it is ubiquitous: Two recent reports showed that only 25% of users produced almost all content on Twitter (now X) and TikTok (Bestvater, 2024; McClain et al., 2021).

Together, these two groups of findings suggest that most people are likely to 1) perceive themselves as less expressive on social media than offline (due to self-censorship or constraint on social media) but 2) not perceive others this way (due to exaggerations of others' expressions on social media). The present research considered a general normative tendency that may accordingly arise in context-framed ratings of the Big Five personality traits. Prior research has shown that Big Five ratings tend to be higher when the reports are framed for social contexts and roles in which people feel freer to express themselves (Fleeson & Wilt, 2010; Sheldon et al., 1997). Thus, it was expected that people would perceive their traits as lower on social media compared to offline but perceive this effect as attenuated in others. The hypothesis here follows prior reports showing lower levels of the Big Five on social media than offline in self-perceptions (e.g., Bunker & Kwan, 2021; 2024; Bunker et al., 2021) but is a novel test of how people perceive others between the two contexts.

## The Present Research

The present research examined context-framed (offline vs. social media) perceived similarity across five studies. The studies shared a common paradigm where participants were asked to complete at least four versions of a personality measure in a 2 (self vs. other) x 2 (offline vs. social media) design. However, the studies featured different methodological extensions to test the replicability of the effects (e.g., different specifications of the "other" target, personality measure used), as detailed further below. Each study sought to address the following research question at both within-perceiver and normative levels:

*Do self-perceptions offline vs. on social media contrast with those perceived in others? (Research Question)*

## Analytic Approach

Within-perceiver analyses were presented first to observe profile agreements across perceptions of context-framed Big Five reports. Then, normative level analyses are presented to observe trends across the sample and the tests of the hypothesis.

### *Profile Agreement*

To address this question at the within-perceiver level, profile agreements were calculated between the (a) offline self vs. social media self, and subsequently compared to the profile agreements between (b) offline other vs. social media other. The Profile.r function in the R package, multicon (Sherman, 2015; Sherman & Serfass, 2015), was used to calculate the profile agreements. In this procedure, agreements are assessed via the correlation between two sets of items for every participant. The correlations control for normativeness (i.e., the degree to which a person's traits match the average or "normative" profile; Furr, 2008), as normativeness confounds perceived similarity (i.e., people tend to perceive themselves like others do; Wood & Furr, 2016). It is therefore important to ask whether there is perceived similarity in the characteristics that distinguish a target from other people (Borkenau & Leising, 2016). There are different available methods to control for normativeness in responding (e.g., standardizing or removing normative profile from scores). The Profile.r function does so by first computing the normative (average) profile across participants and then predicting each individual profile using linear regression. Residuals are saved and then used to calculate the distinct profile agreement, which represents participants' perceived similarity between the two sets, controlling for the normative profile. Distinct profile correlations were used to calculate agreement in the present research.[1]

Following prior recommendations (i.e., at least 8 items per set to conduct a profile agreement analysis; Kenny et al., 2006; Rogers et al., 2018), profile correlations between sets were calculated for all items in the relevant Big Five measure (items ≥ 15 across studies). Items assessing neuroticism were all scored to be in the same socially desirable direction as the other Big Five (i.e., emotional stability) prior to the overall profile calculations. Profile correlations were interpreted as .05 = very weak, .1 = weak, .2 = moderate, .3 = strong, and .4 = very strong (Funder & Ozer, 2019). Throughout the report, profile correlations are referred to as *q* instead of the usual *r* to denote that items are the unit of analysis rather than individuals (see Wood & Furr, 2016).

### *Mean Level Differences*

At the normative level, ANOVAs were conducted to test the effects of context, target, and trait on perceptions. In the event of a significant interaction between context and target (or three-way interaction between context, target, and trait)[2], the primary inferential test was whether differences between offline and social media contexts varied between self-perception vs. and perception of others. These comparisons were examined through post-hoc tests and estimates of

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[1] In some instances, running Profile.r induced errors due to participants' responses (e.g., rows with zero variance or perfect correlations of ±1 between sets). This error was resolved by omitting auxiliary computations from the Profile.r function (e.g., testing profile correlations against baselines). The available code documents the modifications in all relevant cases (see https://osf.io/93ajn/overview?view_only=d389d3c571d04a3eaafef67b4a1543ed).

[2] For exploratory precision checks, ANCOVAs were also run to see whether significant interaction effects replicated while controlling for age, gender, ethnicity, socioeconomic status, as well as logged phone time and normativeness in the personality reports. These covariates were chosen because reports on personality measures (specifying self-perceptions and/or perceptions of others) have been shown to vary across them (e.g., Bunker et al., 2021; Bunker & Kwan, 2024; Mok & Morris, 2009; Winquist et al., 1998; Rau et al., 2021). Moreover, participants' perceptions tended to correlate with the normative profile across these perceptions in all five studies (see supplemental materials; https://osf.io/93ajn/overview?view_only=d389d3c571d04a3eaafef67b4a1543ed), consistent with prior research (e.g., Wood & Furr, 2016). In all cases where a significant interaction appeared in the main ANOVAs, the effect replicated in the ANCOVA model, as documented in the supplemental materials.

effect size (*d*). By converting Funder & Ozer's (2019) recommendations to *d*, estimates were interpreted as .10 = very weak, .20 = weak, .41 = moderate, .63 = strong, and .87 = very strong. Of interest was whether context similarity (indexed by *d* = offline perception – social media perception) differed between self- and other-perceptions (indexed by $\Delta d = d_{self} - d_{other}$). It was expected that Δ*d*s would be positive, namely that:

*On average, lower reports of the Big Five personality traits on social media vs. offline contexts will be pronounced in the self-perceptions relative to perceptions of others. (Hypothesis)*

For transparency, this hypothesis was formulated inductively from Studies 1-4 and pre-registered before Study 5. For clarity and ease of interpretation across studies, the reports below note when findings in Studies 1-4 were consistent or inconsistent with this hypothesis.

**Overview of the Studies**

The research question and hypothesis were tested in a five-study program. Table 1 shows the methods across studies, overviewing sample source and size, personality measure, context frames, and targets. Demographics for each sample are shown in the Appendix Table A1, and media use statistics are shown in Table A2. All samples were digitally immersed, averaging around 4-6 hours daily on their phone. Participants showed high preferences for Instagram across samples. TikTok and Snapchat were also highly preferred in the college student samples. Facebook was highly preferred in the Prolific sample in Study 3.

**Table 1**
*Overview of Methods in Present Research*

| Method | Study 1 | Study 2 | Study 3 | Study 4 | Study 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Sample | Student (*n* = 556) | Student (*n* = 588) | Prolific (*n* = 270) | Student (T1 *n* = 307) (T2 *n* = 254) | Student (T1 *n* = 125) (T2 *n* = 66) |
| Personality measure | BFI-2-XS (15 items) | BFI-2-S (30 items) | BFI-2-S (30 items) | BFI-2-S (30 items) | BFI-2 (60 items) |
| Context frames | Offline Social media | Offline Social media Social gatherings | Offline Social media | Offline Social media | Offline Social media |
| Targets | Self Typical person | Self Typical person | Self Typical person | Self Peer | Self Typical person Peer |

*Notes.* BFI-2-XS = Big Five Inventory 2 Extra Short form (Soto & John, 2017b). BFI-2-S = Big Five Inventory 2 Short Form (Soto & John, 2017b). BFI-2 = Full Big Five Inventory 2 (Soto & John, 2017a).

Studies 1-3 first examined context-framed (offline vs. social media) personality reports in the self and the typical person. From a symbolic interactionist perspective, social interactions generate perceptions of a generalized other (Mead, 1934)—consisting of the thoughts, feelings, and behaviors of the typical person. Perceptions of the generalized other inform observable ways people perceive the typical person (Kenny, 1994). Study 1 was an initial test of how college students perceive themselves on social media vs. offline, compared to the typical person. Study 2 sought to replicate the effects while using a personality measure with greater internal consistency and construct coverage and address an alternative explanation for self-reports observed in Study 1. Study 3 sought to replicate the effects in a non-college student sample.

Studies 4 and 5 sought to test whether the findings replicated in perceptions of self vs. peers. Prior research showed that perceived similarity, for example, is stronger when the target is close to the self (Biesanz et al., 2007; Kenny & Kashy, 1994; Lee et al., 2009; Selfhout et al., 2009; Srivastava et al., 2010). A peer is also a specific person whereas the typical person is a generalized other. Context-framed differences in the self vs. others on social media may be stronger for targets that the perceiver has less information on (e.g., “the typical person”) compared to a peer they are close with. Accordingly, perceived similarity may vary when the other is a peer compared to the typical person. Additionally, Studies 4 and 5 included longitudinal designs to observe whether the perceptions showed rank-order stability over a period of a few weeks. Study 4 first compared perceptions of the self and peers on social media and in offline contexts. Study 5 examined perceptions of all three targets (self, peer, and typical person) offline and on social media using the personality measure with the greatest construct coverage and internal consistency across the studies.

There were standout findings that replicated across the studies. However, some patterns did not replicate across studies. Therefore, an internal meta-analysis was conducted to examine pooled effects for both profile agreement and mean level differences across the studies. Internal meta-analyses provide general patterns observed within programs with multiple studies (Goh et al., 2016). They offer additional evidence of the replicability of effects, as well as help researchers to determine sample sizes for conducting replications or addressing similar research questions in future work.

**Open Science Statement**

Data, code to reproduce analyses using R version 4.0.0 (R Core Team, 2024), measures, and supplemental materials for all five studies and the internal meta-analysis are available on

OSF: https://osf.io/93ajn/overview?view_only=d389d3c571d04a3eaafef67b4a1543ed. All analyses reported in Studies 1-4 were exploratory at the time of analysis and not preregistered. The mean level analyses and hypothesis were preregistered before Study 5 was conducted (see https://osf.io/s6zrg/overview?view_only=9520ded76f4e434182068776af78de2d). Profile analyses in all of the studies and the internal meta-analysis were suggested during the review process and thus not preregistered.

# Study 1: An Initial Test on College Students

Study 1 sought to test how college students perceived context-framed (offline vs. social media) personality traits in themselves vs. the typical person. College students are heavy social media users and are relatively homogenous in age, socioeconomic status, and education level (Bodford et al., 2021; Bolton et al., 2013; Kim, 2019; Peterson, 2001). Further, self-perceptions in both offline and social media contexts independently predict how college students perceive themselves globally across contexts (Bunker & Kwan, 2024)—suggesting that both offline and mediated experiences uniquely contribute to how college students perceive their personality. College students are thus an ideal population for the initial test of the research question.

## Method

### *Participants and Procedure*

College students ($N$ = 556) participated via a Qualtrics survey for course credit. Twenty-one participants were removed after missing an attention check, yielding a final sample size of 535. The sample of 535 participants could detect weak differences in the Big Five between contexts (*d*s > .12) with .80 power and an alpha of .05. All participants completed personality measures considering two targets (self vs. typical person) and two contexts (offline vs. social media). The presentation order of the contexts was randomized so that half of the participants reported personality perceptions considering the offline context first while the other half considered the social media context first. Participants reported perceptions of the typical person after the self.

### *Measures*

Participants reported perceptions of their and others' personality traits in offline (e.g., "I am someone who [the typical person] tends to be quiet *offline*") and social media ("I am someone who [the typical person] tends to be quiet *on social media*") contexts using 15 items from the Big Five Inventory-2 (Soto & John, 2017b) modified to specify the context, following the frame-of-reference paradigm (Robie et al., 2017; Schulze et al., 2021). Participants indicated agreement with items on a 5-point scale (1 = disagree strongly; 5 = agree strongly). Reliability analyses showed .44 ≤ $\alpha$s ≤ .72 (Table A3), comparable to the .49 ≤ $\alpha$s ≤ .73 range reported in the scale validation (Soto & John, 2017b).

## Results and Discussion

### *Profile Agreement*

Descriptives for distinctive profile agreements between each context for each target are reported in Table 2. The average profile agreement was strong between the self offline and on social media ($q$ = .30), suggesting that participants tended to see themselves similarly between contexts. In contrast, the average profile agreement was moderate between the typical person offline and social media ($q$ = .21), suggesting that participants saw the typical person as less similar between the contexts. Standard deviations for the profile agreements were high (.29 and .30), suggesting there were substantial individual differences.

**Table 2**

*Distinctive Profile Agreement Between Targets and Contexts Across Participants (Studies 1–5)*

| Profile agreement | Study | *n* | *M* | 95% CI | *SD* |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Self – offline and social media | 1 | 522 | .30 | [.27, .32] | .29 |
| | 2 | 532 | .29 | [.27, .31] | .24 |
| | 3 | 261 | .32 | [.30, .35] | .21 |
| | 4 | 247 | .29 | [.26, .31] | .22 |
| | 5 | 86 | .45 | [.41, .49] | .18 |
| Typical person – offline and social media | 1 | 487 | .21 | [.18, .24] | .30 |
| | 2 | 483 | .21 | [.18, .23] | .28 |
| | 3 | 238 | .17 | [.14, .20] | .23 |
| | 5 | 84 | .30 | [.27, .34] | .17 |
| Peer – offline and on social media | 4 | 236 | .32 | [.29, .35] | .23 |
| | 5 | 86 | .44 | [.40, .48] | .18 |

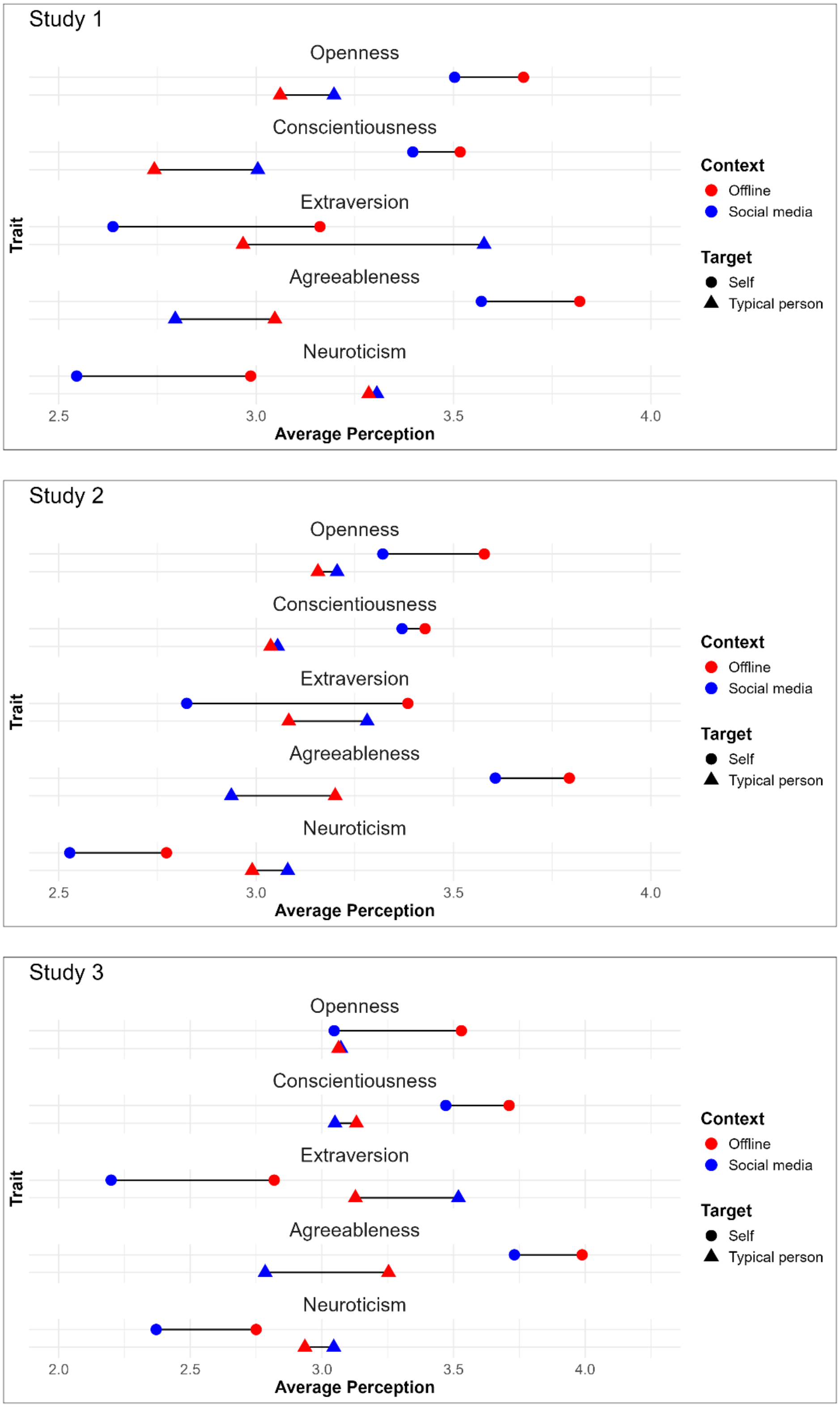
*Note.* Values from Studies 4 and 5 are reported from time 1. Time 2 values are reported in the supplemental materials.

### ***Mean Level Differences***

Mean level results from a three-way ANOVA to examine the effects of context, target, and trait on normative (average) perception are shown in Table A4. There was a significant three-way interaction between the factors ($F(4, 10664) = 35.26$, $p < .001$). Thus, post-hoc comparisons were conducted. Figure 1 shows a visual of the effects, and Table 3 shows effect sizes with 95% CIs and $\Delta d$ between self-perceptions and perceptions of others. Participants perceived themselves to be lower on all the Big Five traits on social media than offline: Openness ($d = .21$, $p = .001$), conscientiousness ($d = .15$, $p = .016$), extraversion ($d = .65$, $p < .001$), agreeableness ($d = .31$, $p < .001$), and neuroticism ($d = .54$, $p < .001$). However, they perceived the opposite for the typical person in terms of openness ($d = -.17$, $p = .006$), conscientiousness ($d = -.32$, $p < .001$), and extraversion ($d = -.75$, $p < .001$). They also perceived no significant differences between contexts in neuroticism for the typical person ($d = -.03$, $p = .679$). Agreeableness showed the only self-other consistency whereby participants also perceived the typical person to be less agreeable on social media ($d = .31$, $p < .001$). Differences in effect size between the context-framed self-perceptions and perceptions of others were very strong for extraversion ($\Delta d$ = 1.40), moderate for conscientiousness ($\Delta d$ = .47) and neuroticism ($\Delta d$ = .57), weak for openness ($\Delta d$ = .38), and agreeableness showed no difference ($\Delta d$ = .00). These findings are consistent with the hypothesis for 4/5 traits (all except agreeableness).

**Figure 1**

*Average Perceptions of Offline and Social Media Traits in the Self and the Typical Person (Studies 1-3)*




*Note*. $N$ = 535 (Study 1), 546 (Study 2), and 262 (Study 3).

**Table 3**

*Effect Sizes with 95% Confidence Intervals of the Differences Between Normative Perceptions in Contexts Within Each Target (Studies 1–5)*

| Comparison | Study | Trait<br>Openness | Conscientiousness | Extraversion | Agreeableness | Neuroticism |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | **Effect size (*d*) with 95% CI** | | | | |
| Self: offline - social media | 1 | .21 [.09, .33] | .15 [.03, .27] | .65 [.53, .77] | .31 [.19, .43] | .54 [.42, .66] |
| | 2 | .38 [.27, .50] | .09 [−.03, .21] | .84 [.72, .96] | .28 [.16, .40] | .37 [.25, .48] |
| | 3 | .71 [.54, .88] | .35 [.18, .53] | .91 [.74, 1.08] | .38 [.21, .55] | .56 [.39, .73] |
| | 4 | .43 [.26, .61] | .10 [−.08, .27] | .84 [.66, 1.01] | .39 [.22, .56] | .41 [.24, .58] |
| | 5 | .52 [.22, .82] | .00 [−.29, .30] | .39 [.09, .68] | .25 [−.05, .55] | .54 [.25, .84] |
| Typical person: offline - social media | 1 | −.17 [−.29, −.05] | −.32 [−.44, −.20] | −.75 [−.87, −.63] | .31 [.19, .43] | −.03 [−.15, .09] |
| | 2 | −.07 [−.19, .04] | −.03 [−.15, .09] | −.30 [−.42, −.18] | .39 [.27, .51] | −.13 [−.26, −.02] |
| | 3 | −.01 [−.19, .16] | .12 [−.05, .29] | −.58 [−.75, −.40] | .69 [.52, .86] | −.16 [−.34, .01] |
| | 5 | −.02 [−.32, .28] | −.03 [−.33, .26] | −.53 [−.83, −.23] | .60 [.31, .90] | −.09 [−.39, .21] |
| Peer: offline - social media | 4 | .22 [.05, .40] | .12 [−.06, .29] | .56 [.39, .74] | .20 [.03, .37] | .38 [.21, .56] |
| | 5 | .52 [.22, .82] | .22 [−.08, .51] | .41 [.11, .70] | .36 [.06, .66] | .34 [.05, .64] |
| | | **Difference in effect size (Δ*d*)** | | | | |
| Self vs. typical person | 1 | .38 | .47 | 1.40 | .00 | .57 |
| | 2 | .46 | .12 | 1.14 | −.11 | .50 |
| | 3 | .72 | .23 | 1.49 | −.31 | .72 |
| | 5 | .54 | .03 | .92 | −.35 | .63 |
| Self vs. peer | 4 | .21 | −.02 | .28 | .19 | .03 |
| | 5 | .00 | −.22 | −.02 | −.11 | .20 |

*Note.* Values from Studies 4 and 5 are reported from time 1. Time 2 values are reported in the supplemental materials.

# Study 2:

# Replication, Addressing Internal Consistency, and Addressing an Alternative Explanation for Self-reports

Study 2 sought to replicate the findings in Study 1. Additionally, Study 2 used a measure of the Big Five with greater internal consistency in assessing perceptions of others given the low internal consistency observed in Study 1. As a secondary auxiliary check, Study 2 addressed an alternative explanation for lower self-reports of the Big Five on social media than offline in terms of perceiving the self as less expressive on social media. The findings, documented in the supplemental materials, suggested that self-perceptions on social media are unique to the context (rather than merely reflecting other social contexts).

## Method

### *Participants and Procedure*

College students ($N$ = 588) participated and received course credit via an online survey with the same design as in Study 1, except the self-perceived Big Five was also reported for social gatherings (see supplemental materials). Forty-two participants were removed after missing an attention check, yielding a final sample size of 546. The sample of 546 participants could detect weak differences in the Big Five between contexts ($d$s > .12) with .80 power and an alpha of .05.

### *Measures*

Participants reported perceptions of their and others' personality traits with the 30-item version of the Big Five Inventory-2 (Soto & John, 2017b) modified to specify offline and social media contexts in the same way as in Study 1. Reliability analyses showed $\alpha$s ranging from .49-

.81 (see Table A3), suggesting improvement from Study 1, and comparability to the .49-.73 range reported in the scale validation (Soto & John, 2017b). Descriptives are shown in Table A3.

## Results and Discussion

### *Profile Agreement*

Profile agreements are shown in Table 2. The patterns in Study 1 replicated: Profile agreement was strong between the self offline and social media ($q$ = .29) but moderate between the typical person offline and social media ($q$ = .21). Standard deviations were also high (.24 and .28), suggesting substantial individual differences.

### *Mean Level Differences*

Average perceptions were also similar to those observed in Study 1 (see Table A4 for ANOVA estimates, Figure 1 for visuals, and Table 3 for effect sizes). There was a significant three-way interaction between the context, target, and trait ($F(4, 10880) = 30.41$, $p < .001$). Post-hoc comparisons showed that participants perceived themselves to be lower on 4/5 traits on social media than offline: Openness ($d$ = .38, $p$ < .001), extraversion ($d$ = .84, $p$ < .001), agreeableness ($d$ = .28, $p$ < .001), and neuroticism ($d$ = .37, $p$ < .001). In contrast to Study 1, the difference between self-perceived conscientiousness between the contexts was very weak and insignificant ($d$ = .09, $p$ = .151). Perceptions of the typical person showed similar patterns as those observed in Study 1 but were weaker in effect size: Openness ($d$ = -.07, $p$ = .231), conscientiousness ($d$ = -.03, $p$ = .664), extraversion ($d$ = -.30, $p$ < .001), and neuroticism ($d$ = -.13, $p$ = .027). Also, like Study 1, participants perceived agreeableness to be lower in the typical person on social media than offline ($d$ = .39, $p$ < .001). Differences in effect size between the context-framed self-perceptions and perceptions of others were very strong for extraversion ($\Delta d$ = 1.14), moderate for openness ($\Delta d$ = .46) and neuroticism ($\Delta d$ = .50), and very weak for conscientiousness ($\Delta d$ = .12). The difference in agreeableness was very weak and in the opposite direction as the other traits ($\Delta d$ = -.11). These findings are consistent with the hypothesis for 3/5 traits: openness, extraversion, and neuroticism. The hypothesis was not supported for conscientiousness and agreeableness.

## Study 3: Testing the Effects Beyond College Students

Study 3 examined whether the main findings regarding profile agreements and the test of the mean level hypothesis in Studies 1 and 2 replicated in a non-college student sample.

### Method

#### *Participants and Procedure*

Prolific workers ($N$ = 270) completed the personality measures in the same design as in Studies 1 and 2 and received $2.17 for their participation. Eight participants were removed after missing a correct answer to an attention check item, yielding a final sample size of 262. The sample of 262 participants could detect weak differences in the Big Five between contexts (*d*s > .17) with .80 power and an alpha of .05.

#### *Measures*

Like Study 2, participants completed the versions of the 30-item version of the Big Five Inventory-2 (Soto & John, 2017b) modified to specify offline and social media contexts. Reliability analyses showed acceptable $\alpha$s, except low internal consistency appeared for perceptions of others' openness in both contexts (offline $\alpha$ = .52; social media $\alpha$ = .58). Descriptive statistics are shown in Table A3.

## Results and Discussion

### *Profile Agreement*

Profile agreements were similar to those observed in Studies 1 and 2 (see Table 2). Profile agreement was strong between the self offline and social media ($q$ = .32) but weak between the typical person offline and social media ($q$ = .17). Standard deviations were high across the profile agreements (.21 and .23).

### *Mean Level Differences*

ANOVA results (Table A4) showed a significant three-way interaction between context, target, and trait ($F$(4, 5180) = 28.74, $p$ < .001). Post-hoc comparisons showed similar patterns to those observed in Studies 1 and 2 (see Figure 1 and Table 3). First, participants perceived themselves as lower on the Big Five on social media than offline for all five traits: Openness ($d$ = .71, $p$ < .001). conscientiousness ($d$ = .35, $p$ < .001), extraversion ($d$ = .91, $p$ < .001), agreeableness ($d$ = .38, $p$ < .001), neuroticism ($d$ = .56, $p$ < .001). Second, they perceived very weak and not significant differences between contexts for the typical person in terms of openness ($d$ = -.01, $p$ = .883), conscientiousness ($d$ = .12, $p$ = .173), and neuroticism ($d$ = -.16, $p$ = .067). They also perceived the typical person to be more extraverted on social media ($d$ = -.58, $p$ < .001). Participants perceived the typical person, like the self, as less agreeable on social media than offline ($d$ = .69, $p$ < .001). Differences in effect size between the context-framed self-perceptions and perceptions of others were very strong for extraversion ($\Delta d$ = 1.49), strong for openness ($\Delta d$ = .72) and neuroticism ($\Delta d$ = .72), and weak for conscientiousness ($\Delta d$ = .23). The difference in agreeableness was weak and in the opposite direction as the other traits ($\Delta d$ = -.31). These findings are consistent with the hypothesis for 4/5 traits (all except agreeableness).

## Study 4: Testing the Effect on Perceptions of Peers and Temporal Stability

The primary goal of Study 4 was to examine whether the effects replicated with a different target when perceiving others. Participants were asked to invite a peer to complete the study. Instead of perceptions of the typical person, participants were asked to report their perceptions of their peers. Another aim of Study 4 was to explore whether the context-framed perceptions show temporal stability. Global personality assessments are relatively stable in self-reports (Church et al., 2012; Gnambs, 2014) and perceptions of others (Srivastava et al., 2010) over periods of a few weeks. Whether perceptions of the self and others with explicit offline and social media context frames are stable over time is unknown. Rank-order stability (i.e., participants' positions relative to others in the sample) was accordingly examined in the context-framed perceptions. Following prior research (e.g., Srivastava et al., 2010), the present research sought to test the stability over 2-3 weeks.

### Method

#### *Participants and Procedure*

College students and their peers participated in one or both Qualtrics surveys over 2-3 weeks ($N_{T1}$ = 307; $N_{T2}$ = 254). After removing participants who failed attention checks, the final sample included 291 participants who participated in at least one of the surveys ($N_{T1}$ = 254; $N_{T2}$ = 218). Participants received course credit for their participation (or helped their peer receive course credit). The samples could detect weak differences in the Big Five between contexts (*d*s > .19) with .80 power and an alpha of .05. All participants completed personality measures considering two targets (self vs. peer) and two contexts (offline vs. social media). The presentation order of the contexts was randomized. Participants reported personality perceptions of their peer after the self. Participants completed the same measures with the same design at both time 1 and time 2.

### *Measures*

For both the self and peer targets, participants reported perceptions with the short version of the Big Five Inventory-2 (Soto & John, 2017b) modified to specify offline and social media contexts. When reporting their perceptions of peer targets, participants were instructed to consider the peer whom they invited to participate in the study or who invited them. The participants then indicated agreement with each item in terms of their peer (e.g., "*They are* someone who tends to be quiet *offline*/*on social media*"). Table A3 shows all descriptive statistics and $\alpha$s. Reliability analyses showed $.61 \leq \alpha\text{s} \leq .83$ (see Appendix A1), suggesting improved internal consistency than the $.49 \leq \alpha\text{s} \leq .73$ range reported in the scale validation (Soto & John, 2017b).

## Results and Discussion

Effects observed at time 1 generally replicated at time 2. The main text contains values from time 1. The supplemental materials show values from time 2. The few cases where a finding did not replicate at time 2 are reported in the main text along with the relevant finding from time 1.

### *Profile Agreement*

Profile agreements are shown in Table 2. In contrast to profile agreement between offline and social media contexts observed in Studies 1–3 in the self compared to the typical person, agreement between the contexts was relatively strong for *both* the self ($q$ = .29) and peers ($q$ = .32). This finding thus failed to replicate the patterns observed in Studies 1-3, whereby perceived similarity between offline and social media contexts varied between the self and others. Like

Studies 1–3, standard deviations were high across the profile agreements (.22 and .23), suggesting substantial individual differences.

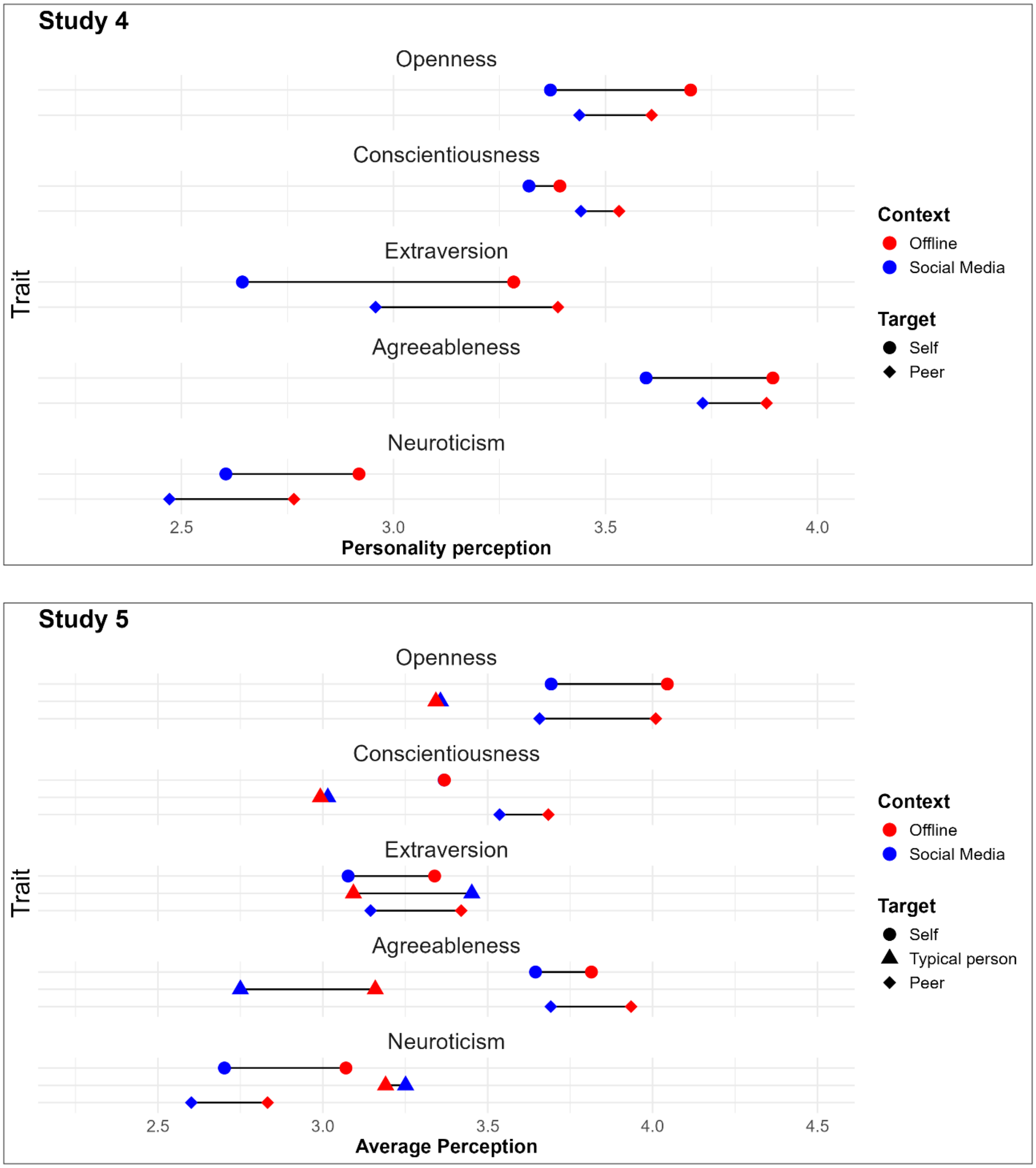
***Mean Level Differences***

Results from a three-way ANOVA to examine the effects of context, target, and trait on normative perceptions are shown in Table A5. Unlike Studies 1-3, there was no significant three-way interaction between context, target, and trait. There were significant interactions between context and target ($F(1, 5041) = 5.88$, $p = .015$), context and trait ($F(4, 5041) = 11.74$, $p < .001$), and target and trait ($F(4, 5041) = 7.88$, $p < .001$). Post-hoc comparisons showed that perceptions of lower levels of the Big Five on social media than offline were pronounced in the self ($d = .43$, 95% CI [.35, .51], $p < .001$) relative to peers ($d = .30$, 95% CI [.22, .37], $p < .001$). These findings are in the direction of the hypothesis, but the relevant difference in effect size between the self and peers ($\Delta d = .14$) was considerably weaker than those observed in the previous studies comparing the self and the typical person (cf. Table 3). Taken together, these findings do not replicate the findings from Studies 1-3, which showed generally stronger differences and trait-specific patterns in participants' context-framed perceptions of themselves vs. typical person.

For a clearer comparison to the previous studies, pairwise comparisons of the context differences for each target are reported (see Figure 2 and Table 3). Like the previous studies, participants tended to perceive themselves as lower on the Big Five on social media than offline, showing significant differences for all traits except conscientiousness: openness ($d = .43$, $p < .001$), conscientiousness ($d = .10$, $p = .244$), extraversion ($d = .84$, $p < .001$), agreeableness ($d = .39$, $p < .001$), and neuroticism ($d = .41$, $p < .001$). Participants also tended to perceive their peers as having lower levels of the Big Five on social media compared to offline. However, participants perceived the pattern as weakly attenuated in their peers for 3/5 traits: openness ($d$ = .22, $p$ = .012, $\Delta d$ = .21), extraversion ($d$ = .56, $p$ < .001, $\Delta d$ = .28), agreeableness ($d$ = .20, $p$ = .025, $\Delta d$ = .19). Of note, at time 2, perceptions of openness ($d_{T2}$ = .16; $p$ = .090) and agreeableness ($d_{T2}$ = .09, $p$ = .378) in peers were not significantly different between offline and social media contexts. Perceptions of peers for the remaining two traits were similar to the self-perceptions ($-.02 \leq \Delta ds \leq .03$): conscientiousness ($d$ = .12, $p$ = .179) and neuroticism ($d$ = .39, $p$ < .001). Only 2/5 (openness and extraversion) thus showed similar consistency with the hypothesis observed in Studies 1-3, and the self-other differences in context similarity were weak for these two traits.

**Figure 2**

*Average Perceptions of Offline and Social Media Traits in the Self and Peers (Study 4) and all Three Targets (Study 5)*




*Note.* $N$ = 254 (Study 4). $N$ = 88 (Study 5).

### ***Rank-Order Stability***

For exploratory purposes, rank-order stability in the context-framed perceptions was examined (see supplemental materials for full list of coefficients). Correlations between rank-orders at T1 and T2 ranged from .49 to .69, suggesting strong temporal stability in the context-framed perceptions for both targets.

## Study 5:

## Testing the Effects Across Targets Using a Measure of The Big Five With Greater Internal Consistency and Construct Coverage

Study 5 had several goals to address limitations of the previous studies. First, Studies 1–4 used Big Five measures with weaknesses in internal consistency (some $\alpha$s < .7). Study 5 sought to address this issue by using the full 60-item version of the Big Five Inventory-2 (Soto & John, 2017a) to assess perceptions of personality in the self and others with greater internal consistency and construct coverage. Second, the previous studies incorporated different designs. That is, Studies 1-3 examined perceptions of others in terms of the typical person, and Study 4 examined perceptions of others in terms of peers over two time points. In Study 5, participants completed measures of all three targets (self, peers, and the typical person) at two time points. The aim was to observe whether findings from the previous studies replicated in a full design incorporating all targets over time. Third, targets were not randomized in Studies 1–4, which may have influenced participant responses. Participants reported perceptions of the self, peer, and typical person in a randomized order in Study 5 (in addition to randomizing contexts within targets).

## Method

### *Participants and Procedure*

College students and their peers participated in at least one of two Qualtrics surveys over 2-3 weeks ($N_{T1} = 125$; $N_{T2} = 66$) for course credit. After removing participants who failed attention checks[3], the final sample included 115 participants who participated in at least one survey ($N_{T1} = 88$; $N_{T2} = 56$). The samples could detect weak differences in the Big Five between contexts (*d*s > .38) with .80 power and an alpha of .05. Participants completed personality measures considering three targets (self versus peer versus typical person) and two contexts (offline versus social media). The presentation order of target and context was randomized. Participants completed the same measures with the same design at both time 1 and time 2.

### *Measures*

Participants reported perceptions for all targets and contexts using context-framed versions of the 60-item Big Five Inventory-2 (Soto & John, 2017a). The context-framing followed the approach in the previous studies. Table A3 shows descriptive statistics and $\alpha$s. All targets and contexts showed $\alpha$s $\geq .70$ with only two exceptions: offline extraversion ($\alpha = .68$) and agreeableness ($\alpha = .66$) of the typical person at time 2.

## Results and Discussion

Like Study 4, effects observed at time 1 generally replicated at time 2. Thus, following Study 4, the main text contains values from time 1, and the supplemental materials show values from time 2. The few cases where a finding did not replicate at time 2 are reported in the main text along with the relevant finding from time 1.

[3] Study 5 used a different attention check developed by Hauser and Schwarz (2016) than in Studies 1-4.

### ***Profile Agreement***

Profile agreements across traits are shown in Table 2.[4] Corroborating findings from Studies 1–4, profile agreement between offline and social media contexts was stronger for the self ($q$ = .45) and peers ($q$ = .44) than the typical person ($q$ = .30). These findings suggest that people perceive themselves and peers similarly between the two contexts, but they perceive the typical person as different between the contexts. Standard deviations across the profile agreements (*SD*s = .18) were attenuated compared to Studies 1–4, but still suggest individual differences.

### ***Mean Level Differences***

A three-way ANOVA was conducted to examine the effects of context, target, and trait on normative perception (see Table A5 for ANOVA estimates, Figure 2 for a visual of the effects, and Table 3 for effect sizes). There was a significant three-way interaction between context, target, and trait ($F(8, 4230) = 6.94$, $p < .001$). Post hoc comparisons showed that participants perceived themselves as having lower levels of 3/5 traits on social media than offline: openness ($d$ = .52, $p$ < .001), extraversion ($d$ = .39, $p$ = .009), and neuroticism ($d$ = .54, $p$ < .001). Differences in agreeableness did not reach significance ($d$ = .25, $p$ = .090), and there were no differences in conscientiousness ($d$ = .00, $p$ = .993).

Participants perceived the typical person as more extraverted on social media than offline ($d$ = -.53, $p$ < .001). Participants did not perceive significant differences between offline and social media contexts in the typical person in terms of openness ($d$ = -.02, $p$ = .890), and

[4] The measure in Study 5 had a larger number of items per trait relative to the other studies. Thus, for exploratory purposes, profile agreement analyses were conducted for each individual trait in Study 5 (see supplemental materials). Overall, participants perceived moderate to strong offline-social media similarity in themselves and peers for most traits ($\approx .2 \leq q$s $\leq .3$) but weaker offline-social media similarity in the typical person (all $q$s < .20 except openness at T2).

neuroticism ($d$ = -.09, $p$ = .545). Differences between the effects regarding these three traits and those in the self-perceptions were moderate to very strong (.54 ≤ Δ$d$s ≤ .92). Participants perceived context-framed perceptions as similar between the self and typical person for the remaining two traits. Specifically, like self-perceptions, they did not perceive the typical person has having different levels of conscientiousness ($d$ = -.03, $p$ = .820, Δ$d$ = .03) between the two contexts. Participants also perceived agreeableness on social media as lower than offline in the typical person ($d$ = .60, $p$ < .001), but the context difference was stronger than in self-perceptions (Δ$d$ = -.35), opposite of the hypothesis. These findings are thus consistent with the hypothesis for 3/5 traits (openness, extraversion, and neuroticism) when comparing the self to the typical person.

Perceptions of peers were similar to self-perceptions. Openness ($d$ = .52, $p$ < .001) and extraversion ($d$ = .41, $p$ = .006) showed lower levels on social media than offline. Self-perceptions showed almost the same differences regarding openness and extraversion (-.02 ≤ Δ$d$s ≤ .00). Neuroticism differences perceived between the contexts in peers ($d$ = .34, $p$ = .021) were weaker compared to the self-perceptions (Δ$d$ = .20). Of note, at time 2, differences in neuroticism perceived between the contexts in peers in neuroticism were not statistically significant ($d_{T2}$ = .23, $p$ = .292). Agreeableness was perceived as lower on social media than offline in peers ($d$ = .36, $p$ = .015) and was stronger than the self-perception difference (Δ$d$ = -.11), but, like the self-perceptions, this difference was not significant at time 2 ($d_{T2}$ = .26, $p$ = .165; Δ$d_{T2}$ = .03). Also like the self-perceptions, differences in conscientiousness between the contexts were not significant in peers, and the differences appeared to be only somewhat stronger than self-perceptions ($d$ = .22, $p$ = .140, Δ$d$ = -.22). Thus, these findings are thus consistent with the hypothesis for only 1/5 traits (neuroticism) when comparing the self to peers.

### ***Rank-Order Stability***

For exploratory purposes, rank-order stabilities of the context-framed perceptions were examined (see supplemental materials for full list of coefficients). Only 29 participants had valid data for perceptions of all targets in both contexts and completed both surveys. Within this limitation, rank-order stability showed a wider range ($.26 \leq r$s $\leq .82$) than in Study 4 ($.49 \leq r$s $\leq .69$) but mostly strong stability. Given the small sample size, these interpretations should be taken with caution.

## Internal Meta-Analysis of the Studies

As shown in summary Table 4, there were some standout findings across the studies, especially in terms of profile agreements, and mean level effects for openness, extraversion, agreeableness, and neuroticism. However, there were some noteworthy inconsistencies across studies, particularly regarding mean level effects for conscientiousness. To provide a synthesis of across studies, an internal meta-analysis of the findings was conducted to observe 1) pooled profile agreements ($q$) between offline and social media personality for each target and 2) mean level differences ($\Delta d$) reflecting how pooled offline–social media similarity ($d$) contrasted between self- and other-perceptions across the five studies. The internal meta-analysis was conducted with the *metafor* package (Viechtbauer, 2010). Only time 1 values were used from Studies 4 and 5 to calculate the pooled effects because the time 2 values were not independent from time 1.

**Table 4**

*Summary of the Key Effects*

| Study | Targets | Key Effects: Profile agreement between offline and social media contexts by target | Key Effects: Mean level differences between targets in context-framed perception |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Self, typical person | Self: Strong<br>Typical person: Moderate | Weak to very strong effects for 4/5 traits (O, C, E, N) |
| 2 | Self, typical person | Self: Strong<br>Typical person: Moderate | Moderate to very strong effects for 3/5 traits (O, E, N) |
| 3 | Self, typical person | Self: Strong<br>Typical person: Moderate | Weak to very strong effects for 4/5 traits (O, C, E, N) |
| 4 | Self, peer | Self: Strong<br>Peers: Strong | Weak effects for 2/5 traits (O, E) |
| 5 | Self, typical person, peer | Self: Very strong<br>Typical person: Strong<br>Peers: Very strong | Moderate to very strong effects for 3/5 traits (O, E, N) comparing self vs. typical person<br>Weak effects for 1/5 traits (N) comparing self vs. peer |

*Note:* Effect size interpretations are drawn from Funder and Ozer (2019): Profile agreements are interpreted as weak = .1, moderate = .2, strong = .3, and very strong = .4; Mean level effects indicated by a positive $\Delta d$ (i.e., $d_{self} - d_{other}$ where each $d$ = offline perception – social media perception) are interpreted as 10 = very weak, .20 = weak, .41 = moderate, .63 = strong, and .87 = very strong. O = Openness, C = Conscientiousness, E = Extraversion, A = Agreeableness, N = Neuroticism.

## Results

### *Profile Agreement*

Table 5 shows the pooled profile agreement coefficients and 95% confidence intervals for each comparison. The profile agreement coefficients ($q$) were transformed to Fisher's $z$ prior to pooling and estimating the overall effect, and then transformed back to $q$ for reporting. A mixed-effects model was fitted to test whether the pooled effects were significantly different across targets. Target moderated the pooled profile agreements ($Q(2) = 10.64$, $p = .005$). Comparisons between the self and others showed no significant difference between the pooled profile agreements in self vs. peers ($Z = -.84$, $p = .403$), but the difference in the pooled profile agreements between self vs. typical person was significant ($Z = 2.82$, $p = .005$). Likewise, the peer vs. typical person was significant ($z = 2.49$, $p = .013$). These findings suggest that the self and peers were both perceived as strongly similar between offline and social media contexts across the studies. In contrast, the typical person was perceived as moderately similar between the two contexts. Of note, the sample size weighted mean standard deviations indicated substantial individual differences in profile agreements for all three targets across the studies.

**Table 5**

*Meta-Analytic Estimates of Distinctive Profile Agreements Across Studies*

| Profile Agreement | *k* | *n* | Pooled *q* | 95% CI | *SD* |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Self – offline and social media | 5 | 1,648 | .31 | [.26, .35] | .25 |
| Typical person – offline and social media | 4 | 1,292 | .21 | [.16, .26] | .27 |
| Peer – offline and on social media | 2 | 322 | .36 | [.24, .46] | .22 |

*Note.* *k* = number of effect sizes; *n* = total sample size. *SD* = sample size weighted mean standard deviation.

***Mean Level Differences***

Table 6 shows the pooled effects reflecting how offline-social media similarity (*d*) contrasted between each self-other comparison ($\Delta d$). Offline-social media similarity (*d*) for self-perceptions was pooled across Studies 1-3 and 5 for comparison to the pooled typical person estimate, and then pooled across Studies 4 and 5 for comparison to the pooled peer estimate.

**Table 6**

*Meta-Analytic Estimates of Differences in Context-Framed Perceptions Between Self and Others Across Studies*

| Comparison | Trait | *k* | Offline self – Social media self | | Offline other – social media other | | Self *d* – other *d* |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | Pooled *d* | 95% CI | Pooled *d* | 95% CI | Δ*d* |
| Self vs. Typical Person (Studies 1-3, 5) | Openness | 4 | .44 | [.27, .61] | −.09 | [−.17, −.01] | .53 |
| | Conscientiousness | 4 | .15 | [.05, .24] | −.07 | [−.27, .12] | .22 |
| | Extraversion | 4 | .75 | [.61, .90] | −.54 | [−.74, −.34] | 1.29 |
| | Agreeableness | 4 | .32 | [.25, .39] | .48 | [.30, .66] | −.16 |
| | Neuroticism | 4 | .47 | [.38, .56] | −.09 | [−.17, −.02] | .56 |
| Self vs. Peer (Studies 4 & 5) | Openness | 2 | .45 | [.30, .60] | .34 | [.05, .63] | .11 |
| | Conscientiousness | 2 | .07 | [−.08, .22] | .15 | [.00, .30] | −.08 |
| | Extraversion | 2 | .63 | [.19, 1.07] | .52 | [.37, .67] | .11 |
| | Agreeableness | 2 | .36 | [.21, .51] | .24 | [.09, .39] | .12 |
| | Neuroticism | 2 | .44 | [.30, .59] | .37 | [.22, .52] | .07 |

*Note. k* = number of effect sizes for each self-other comparison. Pooled *d* values (offline – social media) were estimated via random-effects meta-analysis separately for each target. Δ*d* = differences between pooled *d*s between self and other.

Across Studies 1-3 and 5, which compared the self vs. typical person, participants perceived themselves to be lower on all five of the Big Five traits on social media than offline. However, they perceived the opposite for the typical person in terms of openness, extraversion, and neuroticism. These self-other asymmetries were very strong for extraversion and moderate for openness and neuroticism. Participants did not perceive observable differences between contexts in conscientiousness for the typical person across studies, potentially due to substantial cross-study inconsistency (see Table 3), and the self-other difference was weak across studies. Agreeableness showed the only self-other consistency whereby participants also perceived the typical person to be less agreeable on social media. In sum, these internal meta-analytic findings are in line with the hypothesis of the present research regarding 3/5 traits (openness, extraversion, and neuroticism) when comparing the self vs. the typical person.

Across Studies 4 and 5, which compared the self vs. peers, participants perceived both themselves and their peers as lower on all traits on social media than offline except conscientiousness. Self-peer differences were very weak. The findings suggest that participants perceived the context-framed perceptions of themselves and peers similarly across Studies 4 and 5. In sum, these internal meta-analytic findings are not consistent with the hypothesis of the present research when comparing the self vs. peers for any of the five traits beyond very weak effects.

## General Discussion

The present research addressed whether self-perceptions offline vs. on social media contrast with those perceived in others. Drawing on Whole Trait Theory (Fleeson & Jayawickreme, 2015; Jayawickreme et al., 2019), a multi-study mapping of context-framed person perception was conducted. The five-study program asked participants to report their perceptions of the Big Five personality traits specifying offline and social media contexts. The studies examined different perceptual targets (self, typical person, and peers), used various Big Five measures, and drew from different samples (college student and Prolific) to examine the replicability of two types of perceived similarity. First, within-perceiver analyses were conducted to observe whether profile agreements between perceptions of context-framed reports of the Big Five personality traits were the same across targets. Second, mean level analyses were conducted to observe normative trends in the context-framed perceptions. The following hypothesis was tested regarding mean levels: Lower reports of the Big Five personality traits on social media vs. offline contexts observed in prior research (e.g., Bunker & Kwan, 2021; 2024) were expected to replicate in self-perceptions, suggesting that people perceive themselves as constrained on social media. However, this pattern was expected to be less pronounced in perceptions of others, whom people may not view as constrained on social media due to situational features that may exaggerate others' expressions (see Bayer et al., 2020; McFarland & Ployhart, 2015; Robertson et al., 2024b). Effect sizes were interpreted with benchmarks advocated by Funder and Ozer (2019) denoting very weak, weak, moderate, strong, and very strong benchmarks.

Several findings were replicated across the studies, but there were some inconsistencies and variance in the strength of the effects. An internal meta-analysis showed the following key patterns. First, profile agreements between offline and social media contexts were strong in self-perception and perceptions of peers, but moderate in perceptions of the typical person, suggesting that people perceive themselves more similarly between the two contexts compared to generalized others. This first set of findings thus suggests a case where people do not perceive context-framed personality expression as the same between themselves and (generalized) others.

Context-framed discrepancies between the self and others at the mean level, however, depended on the trait and target. Participants tended to perceive themselves as lower on openness, extraversion, and neuroticism on social media than offline; yet they perceived the opposite or attenuated effects in the typical person. Agreeableness was perceived as lower on social media than offline in both the self and typical person. Relative to the other four traits, differences between the self and the typical person in context-framed perception regarding conscientiousness were weak and showed variation in the effects across studies. Taken together, these patterns suggest moderate to very strong effects in line with the hypothesis regarding context-framed perceptions of three of the Big Five (openness, extraversion, and neuroticism) in the self vs. the typical person. However, participants' context-framed self-perceptions and perceptions of peers were similar regardless of trait, inconsistent with the hypothesis.

Standard deviations were also relatively high across profile agreements (Table 2) and normative means (Table A3), suggesting substantial individual differences. There were also relatively strong rank-order correlations in the context-framed perceptions in Study 4, suggesting that the context-framed perceptions were temporally stable. However, Study 5 showed a wider range of the rank-order correlations. It will be informative for future research to further investigate individual differences and rank-order stability of context-framed person perception. The trait- and target- specific patterns, and implications of the present findings merit further discussion.

**Trait-specific Patterns**

*Extraversion* showed the most robust consistency with the hypothesis when comparing self-perceptions and perceptions of the typical person. The difference in context-framed effect sizes regarding extraversion (meta-analytic $\Delta d$ = 1.29) was very strong, which is rare for psychological research (Funder & Ozer, 2019). Across the present studies, people tended to perceive themselves as less extraverted on social media than offline, but they perceived the opposite effect in the typical person. The situational features of social media platforms offer insight into the observed patterns. Social media are defined, in part, for social interaction (Carr & Hayes, 2015) and may thus relate closely with social traits like extraversion. Within the DIAMONDS framework (Rauthmann et al., 2014), Sociality is a key situational dimension that relates to extraversion (Kuper et al., 2026). Taken together with the present findings, people may not perceive situational contrasts between social media and offline in themselves as the same in other people. Social media profiles with non-normative views and behaviors, favored by algorithms and perceptually dominant (Brady et al., 2023a; Robertson et al., 2024b), may become what people think of as the typical person on social media despite them being misrepresentative of most users and the general population. Indeed, recent work suggests that people tend to misperceive others' social media use in general (Bunker et al., 2026). The typical person is likely more characteristic of social media "lurkers" (see Sun et al., 2014) who are reluctant to post or actively engage with platforms, let alone express non-normative views or behavior on social media. People tend to express more extraversion in situations with social goals (e.g., Fleeson & McCabe, 2012), and observing the opposite effect in the present studies suggests that, when reporting their self-perceptions, participants might have been comparing themselves to the expectations or norms of that context.

*Openness* also showed moderate effects in the same directional pattern whereby people perceived themselves as having lower levels on social media than offline while perceiving the opposite in the typical person (meta-analytic $\Delta d$ = .53). Openness is defined by intellectual curiosity, creative imagination, and aesthetic sensitivity (Soto & John, 2017a), and relates to Intellect within the DIAMONDS framework (Kuper et al., 2026). Intellect stratifies situations on the opportunities to demonstrate intellectual capacity or expression of unusual ideas or points of view, or values that concern lifestyles or politics (Rauthmann et al., 2014). People may not perceive themselves as able to engage in the intellectual, imaginative, or aesthetic opportunities of social media compared to typical others who populate their feeds. At a higher level, openness also shares a "plasticity" higher-order structure with extraversion, which is defined by an individual's tendency to seek out new resources (as opposed to conserving existing resources; DeYoung et al., 2026). Perhaps social media platforms constrain people's active behaviors indicative of extraversion and openness while simultaneously raising the visibility of others' expressions on these two traits. In this way, people might still perceive social media as a situation for Sociality and Intellect, but more so for others than themselves. Future research may examine whether people perceive offline and social media contexts as affording similar opportunities for seeking resources, albeit ones that (are perceived to be) capitalized on more so by others.

*Neuroticism* also showed moderate differences in context-framed perceptions between the self and others (meta-analytic $\Delta d$ = .56). Participants tended to report lower levels of neuroticism on social media than offline while perceiving an attenuated or opposite effect in the typical person. The pattern here suggests one trait where people perceive themselves as more socially desirable on social media than offline (in contrast to the other four traits which show the opposite context-framed pattern regarding social desirability; see Musek, 2007). In Western samples, like those in the present studies, people typically see themselves positively in terms of the Big Five, but neuroticism is one exception where people see themselves as more neurotic than other people (Kim et al., 2019). The exception is perhaps due to neuroticism's low observability (see Connelly & Ones, 2010) or weaker relation to values (Thielmann, 2024) relative to the other four traits. Thus, people's context-framed perceptions of neuroticism may be idiosyncratic due to the trait's unique aspects. Informative directions for future research are thus to test whether the mechanisms underlying context-framed self-other differences vary for extraversion/openness compared to neuroticism.

*Agreeableness* was the only trait that showed repeated inconsistency with the hypothesis. Participants tended to perceive both themselves and others (both peers and the typical person) as less agreeable on social media than offline. The internal meta-analysis showed weak self-other discrepancies such that they perceived the effect as slightly weaker in their peers ($\Delta d$ = .12) but slightly stronger in the typical person ($\Delta d$ = -.16). Agreeableness is defined by compassion, respect, and trust (Soto & John, 2017a). Social media algorithms amplify negative content that may undermine compassion, respect, and trust (e.g., anger and hostility; Milli et al., 2025). A recent review further suggests that people overestimate hostility, negative affect, and other indicators consistent with these facets on social media (Robertson et al., 2024a). Accordingly, the observed patterns regarding agreeableness may suggest an informative qualification to the hypothesized pattern, namely that perceptions of (generalized) others on social media do not uniformly involve higher levels of traits on social media compared to offline contexts. Agreeableness may involve "expressive" behaviors on the low end of the scale. Still, future research needs to untangle if the same mechanism is responsible for why agreeableness is perceived as lower on social media than offline for both self and others. The algorithmic amplification explanation may apply more for perceptions of others than for self-perceptions (where a different process, perhaps online censorship, is responsible; see Ashokkumar et al., 2020).

The agency/communion distinction (Abele & Wojciszke, 2007; Bakan, 1966) corresponding to the higher order structure of the Big Five (Digman, 1997) may offer a general integrative suggestion of the present findings regarding openness and extraversion vs. agreeableness and neuroticism. Specifically, the typical person on social media is perceived as higher on agentic traits like extraversion and openness but lower on communal traits like agreeableness, with neuroticism also shifting in an unfavorable direction. This interpretation suggests that people perceive others' expressions on social media as agentic but non-communal.

*Conscientiousness* showed the most inconclusive patterns across the studies. Participants tended to perceive themselves as significantly lower on conscientiousness on social media than offline in only two of the five studies (the other three studies showed insignificant differences). Perceptions of peers' conscientiousness were insignificant between the two contexts in both Studies 4 and 5. Perceptions of the typical person's conscientiousness between the two contexts varied widely across Studies 1-3 and 5 ($-32 \leq d$s $\leq .12$). The internal meta-analysis showed weak self-other discrepancies (self vs. peer $\Delta d = -.08$; self vs. typical person $\Delta d = .22$). One explanation for the inconclusive findings is that conscientiousness, relative to other traits, is harder for people to differentiate between social media and offline contexts. Items on the conscientiousness sub-scale of the BFI-2 (Soto & John, 2017) such as "Leave a mess, doesn't clean up" and "tends to be lazy" may make more sense when framed for offline contexts, which reflect a three-dimensional physical world, compared to the social media contexts, which reflect two-dimensional digital interfaces. People may also perceive social media as less defined in the Duty dimension of the DIAMONDS framework (e.g., extent to which a situation has a "job that needs to be done" or "rational thinking is called for"; Rauthmann et al., 2014), which relates to conscientiousness (Kuper et al., 2026). Future research may investigate further by assessing the level of certainty in ratings of context-framed perceptions, which may vary by trait or context (or even target).

**Target-specific Patterns**

The present research compared self-perceptions to perceptions of the typical person and peers. These two "other" targets contrast in closeness (peers are closer to the self than the typical person), specificity (people's perceptions of peers represent perceptions of a specific person whereas the typical person represents a generalized other), and familiarity (people are more familiar with their peers than the typical person). Both profile agreement and mean level analyses suggested that context-framed perceptions are similar between the self and peer but vary between the self and typical person. This is consistent with prior research suggesting that people perceive themselves and others more similarly with increased acquaintance (Biesanz et al., 2007) or closeness (Robbins & Krueger, 2005). However, the findings show by extension that people may perceive themselves and close others similarly in terms of *context-framed* attributes. In contrast, people may perceive typical others almost as if they were a different person on social media than offline (at least in terms of extraversion, and to a moderate extent, openness and neuroticism). The findings suggest the need to attend to who the "other" is when examining perceived similarity, and how such assessments may be further complicated by context. Future research may examine whether explicitly measured factors such as target closeness, familiarity, or specificity moderate context-framed perceived similarity.

**Implications**

The present research suggests boundary conditions of social projection and consistency of person perception across situational contexts. Prior research suggests that people tend to perceive others as similar to themselves (Cronbach, 1955; Hughes et al., 2021; Thielmann et al., 2020). Whole Trait Theory additionally suggests that people vary across situations (Fleeson & Jayawickreme, 2015; Jayawickreme et al., 2019). The present findings integrate these two perspectives by suggesting that people do not always perceive others as similar to themselves when considering variance in personality between situational contexts within perceptual targets.[5] The present research focused on social media and offline contexts given the stark contrasts in these two omnibus contexts (Bayer et al., 2020; McFarland & Ployhart, 2015). In future research,

[5] The present focus was on how people perceive context-framed differences in themselves vs. others (i.e., *context similarity within targets*). However, one could also ask how people perceive *target similarity within contexts*. Curious readers may see the supplemental materials for exploratory analyses examining this alternative framing, namely whether perceived similarity between the self and others was the same between offline and social media contexts. One noteworthy finding from these supplemental analyses was that target similarity in both offline and social media contexts was weak or moderate (*q*s = .05–.21). These estimates are consistent with prior evidence for (modest) perceived similarity effects (Ashton & Lee, 2025).

the DIAMONDS framework (Rauthmann et al., 2014) may be useful for thinking about other kinds of situations that change the way people view context-framed perceptions of themselves and how such perception may vary when perceiving other people, as well as the social consequences and mechanisms involved in such self-other (dis)similarities. In doing so, theories of perceived similarity will benefit with the incorporation of situational perspectives.

The present research further suggests directions regarding social accuracy in personality judgment. Studies 4 and 5 in the present work lacked codes to link dyadic responses (i.e., peer pairs) and thus could not evaluate trait perceptions in terms of a conventional benchmark of accuracy used in previous research (e.g., comparing self and informant profiles of personality traits; Biesanz, 2010). However, the present findings suggest that people may have misalignments between how they view themselves and others that are context-specific (e.g., people's ratings of the typical person did not align with the sample average self-perceptions). Past research shows that people are reasonably accurate at making judgements about others' general personality traits based on social media profiles (Back et al., 2010; Human et al., 2021; Orehek & Human, 2017). But whether people make accurate judgments about profile owners' personality traits specifying both offline and social media contexts is unknown**.** Future research may examine whether these effects replicate in context-specified approaches. In doing so, it may be useful to consider that the typical profiles people see on social media that inform their social perception may not be like the social media profiles belonging to participants typically invited to laboratory round-robin studies.

Finally, the present research suggests that incorporating theories of personality may yield applied insights into social perception derived from social media. An emerging body of research has identified social perceptions derived from social media as problematic. Specifically, people perceive a minority expressing non-normative views and behavior to be representative of the general population (Bail, 2022; Barberá & Rivero, 2015; Bestvater, 2024; Brady et al., 2023a; Brady et al., 2023b; Fisher, 2022; Hughes, 2019; McClain et al., 2021; Robertson et al., 2024b; Van Bavel et al., 2024). This research has mostly focused on social perceptions in terms of political and moral beliefs, identifying that social media algorithms exploit biases toward PRIME (prestigious, ingroup, moral, and emotional) content (Brady et al., 2023a). Researchers and the public alike are right to be concerned with how social media impacts beliefs about the outcomes of elections or whether a person has committed a moral transgression. However, a broader goal is to understand the full range of people's perceptions of others' beliefs and behavior. One of the most basic ways to do so is through examining personality traits (John & Robbins, 1993; McAdams, 1995, 1996; McAdams & Pals, 2006), which are susceptible to misalignment between perception and how people actually view themselves (e.g., Kenny, 2004; McCrae & Terracciano, 2006). The present findings suggest that how people perceive offline and social media contrasts in (generalized) others are not the same as in self-perceptions. The broader implication here is that people may have mundane (but impactful) social perceptions derived from social media that extend more broadly than those about politics and morality. Incorporating theories of personality (e.g., Whole Trait Theory; Fleeson & Jayawickreme, 2015; Jayawickreme et al., 2019) into the study of social media may thus offer a more comprehensive approach to understand the relationships between digital technologies and social perception.

## Limitations

Limitations of the present research should be noted. First, the present research utilized samples collected within Western, educated, industrialized, rich, and democratic contexts (WEIRD; Henrich et al., 2010). That is, the samples were from college students in the United

States and Prolific participants. All samples showed heavy mobile phone use (Table A1), suggesting digital immersion with relative variation among participants. Such samples provide a reliable foundation to examine offline and social media perception. However, there are open questions about whether the present findings would generalize to non-Western cultures or individuals in societies with more limited access to social media platforms. Prior work, for example, has shown that while users are more likely to produce social media content in ways consistent with their cultural values, they are more likely to be influenced by content that violates such values (Hsu et al., 2021). Perception between the self and others on social media (and its social consequences) may vary across culturally derived self-construals.

Second, the present research examined perceptions of personality traits specifying social media and offline contexts as omnibus contexts but did not examine individual platforms or offline situations. Study 2 was one exception where "social gatherings" was included as an additional context frame to show that differences perceived between offline and social media contexts were not equivalent to those perceived between offline and social gathering —thereby demonstrating that the observed differences were likely due to the unique situational context of social media rather than social media framing having the same effects as other social contexts. Social media platforms and offline environments rapidly change in today's mobile, digitally intertwined world, raising problems for focusing on particular platforms or situations when comparing online versus offline psychology. Platform preferences in most of the present samples (Table A2) suggest the findings may be contingent on popular platforms with visual-orientated affordances like Instagram, TikTok, and Snapchat. However, explicitly specifying both individual offline and social media contexts in personality measurement could be insightful. The present findings may vary, for example, in potential comparisons between LinkedIn vs. the offline workplace or between more casual platforms vs. interacting with friends offline.

Third, the present research examined personality in terms of the Big Five traits. While the Big Five is arguably the most widely used framework in personality psychology, the framework does not fully represent personality. For example, there is also narrative identity and characteristic adaptation levels of personality (McAdams & Pals, 2006). Other personality traits beyond the Big Five (e.g., humor, intelligence) may also be fruitful for future research to investigate.

## Conclusion

Through a multi-study descriptive mapping of context-framed person perception, the present research suggests that how people perceive themselves and their peers offline versus on social media contrasts from their perceptions of the typical person. The findings imply a need to examine context-framed perceptions to uncover the full picture of whether people perceive themselves and others similarly. Future research is needed to examine the underlying mechanisms that explain trait-specific patterns (especially for offline vs. social media extraversion, which showed very strong self-other asymmetry). More generally, the present research demonstrates the potential of applying personality theory (e.g., Whole Trait Theory; Fleeson & Jayawickreme, 2015) to understand social perception in the context of social media.

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## Appendix

**Table A1**

*Participant Demographics*

| Study | | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Average Age (*SD*) | | 19.14 (2.27) | 19.20 (1.41) | 42.55 (11.73) | 21.63 (5.52) | 19.83 (1.29) |
| Gender | Women | 63.9% | 47.1% | 77.9% | 62.5% | 74.0% |
| | Men | 35.6% | 51.9% | 21.7% | 36.1% | 18.3% |
| | Non-binary or unspecified | 0.6% | 1% | .4% | 1.4% | 7.7% |
| Race/Ethnicity | White | 55.7% | 54.8% | 89.9% | 52.3% | 46.1% |
| | East Asian | 13.5% | 8.9% | 2.3% | 5.3% | 22.6% |
| | Latino | 17.6% | 20.1% | 1.2% | 28.8% | 4.3% |
| | Black | 4.3% | 5.9% | 2.3% | 4.2% | 3.5% |
| | South Asian | 3.8% | 4.1% | 1.2% | 3.2% | N/A |
| | Middle Eastern | 2.1% | 2.6% | N/A | 2.1% | 4.3% |
| | American Indian | 0.2% | 1.7% | N/A | 1.4% | 1.0% |
| | Other | 2.8% | 2.0% | 3.1% | 2.8% | 18.2% |
| SES | Lower | 6.9% | 7.0% | 36.4% | 9.5% | N/A |
| | Lower-middle | 12.6% | 11.1% | 30.6% | 17.2% | N/A |
| | Middle | 37.5% | 36.3% | 31.4% | 44.8% | N/A |
| | Upper-middle | 36.6% | 39.9% | 1.6% | 24.6% | N/A |
| | Upper | 6.4% | 5.7% | 0% | 3.9% | N/A |

*Note.* Participants in Study 5 reported household income levels instead of SES: 6.1% under $10,000, 0% $10,000 - $19,999, 1.7% $20,000 – $29,999, 2.6% $30,000 – $39,999, 2.6% $40,000 – $49,999, 1.7% $50,000 – $74,999, 6.1% $75,000 – $99,999, 12.20% $100,000 – $150,000, 18.3% Over $150,000, and 48.7% reported rather not say.

**Table A2**

*Participant Media Use*

| Study | Logged phone time in minutes *M* (*SD*) | "Which of the following social media do you primarily use/is your favorite?" (%) | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | TikTok | Instagram | Snapchat | Twitter/X | Facebook | Other |
| 1 | 307 (152) | 37% | 25% | 25% | 5% | 1% | 7% |
| 2 | 331 (144) | 28% | 34% | 27% | 6% | 1% | 5% |
| 3 | 230 (154) | 6% | 29% | 1% | 8% | 46% | 10% |
| 4 (T1) | 321 (173) | 34% | 33% | 19% | 5% | 4% | 5% |
| 4 (T2) | 324 (156) | 42% | 27% | 18% | 4% | 4% | 5% |
| 5 (T1) | 316 (162) | 30% | 40% | 9% | 5% | 0% | 16% |
| 5 (T2) | 314 (123) | 29% | 45% | 9% | 4% | 0% | 13% |

**Table A3**

*Descriptives and Reliability Coefficients for Self and Other Perceptions of Offline and Social Media Personality across Studies*

| Trait | Context | Study | Self-perception | | | Perception of the typical person | | | Perception of peers | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | *M* | *SD* | *α* | *M* | *SD* | *α* | *M* | *SD* | *α* |
| Openness | Offline | 1 | 3.68 | .80 | .58 | 3.06 | .69 | .47 | - | - | - |
| | | 2 | 3.58 | .70 | .66 | 3.16 | .51 | .53 | - | - | - |
| | | 3 | 3.53 | .75 | .76 | 3.06 | .44 | .52 | - | - | - |
| | | 4 | 3.70/ 3.69 | .72/.79 | .70/.78 | - | - | - | 3.61/ 3.57 | .76/.76 | .76/.76 |
| | | 5 | 4.04/ 3.99 | .68/.69 | .87/.88 | 3.34/ 3.36 | .59/.64 | .85/.87 | 4.01/ 3.97 | .63/.70 | .84/.86 |
| | Social Media | 1 | 3.50 | .76 | .49 | 3.20 | .73 | .46 | - | - | - |
| | | 2 | 3.32 | .64 | .56 | 3.21 | .54 | .49 | - | - | - |
| | | 3 | 3.05 | .75 | .73 | 3.07 | .53 | .58 | - | - | - |
| | | 4 | 3.37/ 3.37 | .70/.72 | .61/.66 | - | - | - | 3.44/ 3.45 | .70/.70 | .70/.70 |
| | | 5 | 3.69/ 3.67 | .60/.69 | .78/.87 | 3.36/ 3.41 | .57/.60 | .78/.81 | 3.66/ 3.62 | .61/.60 | .80/.81 |
| Conscientiousness | Offline | 1 | 3.52 | .85 | .55 | 2.74 | .70 | .56 | - | - | - |
| | | 2 | 3.43 | .67 | .66 | 3.04 | .53 | .61 | - | - | - |
| | | 3 | 3.71 | .77 | .78 | 3.13 | .52 | .69 | - | - | - |
| | | 4 | 3.39/ 3.37 | .73/.72 | .67/.71 | - | - | - | 3.53/ 3.48 | .77/.74 | .72/.73 |
| | | 5 | 3.37/ 3.38 | .74/.68 | .86/.84 | 2.99/ 2.91 | .53/.47 | .81/.71 | 3.68/ 3.65 | .81/.71 | .90/.85 |
| | Social Media | 1 | 3.40 | .80 | .47 | 3.00 | .73 | .49 | - | - | - |
| | | 2 | 3.37 | .64 | .60 | 3.05 | .60 | .66 | - | - | - |
| | | 3 | 3.47 | .56 | .53 | 3.05 | .56 | .70 | - | - | - |
| | | 4 | 3.32/ 3.29 | .68/.66 | .63/.62 | - | - | - | 3.44/ 3.43 | .65/.64 | .64/.63 |
| | | 5 | 3.37/ 3.29 | .72/.64 | .86/.83 | 3.02/ 2.79 | .63/.50 | .85/.72 | 3.54/ 3.45 | .69/.60 | .86/.81 |

| | | | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Extraversion | Offline | 1 | 3.16 | .92 | .61 | 2.97 | .75 | .55 | | | |
| | | 2 | 3.38 | .77 | .73 | 3.08 | .51 | .50 | | | |
| | | 3 | 2.82 | .86 | .78 | 3.13 | .45 | .52 | | | |
| | | 4 | 3.28/ 3.26 | .82/.75 | .74/.70 | - | - | - | 3.39/ 3.37 | .80/.70 | .75/.66 |
| | | 5 | 3.34/ 3.23 | .71/.71 | .84/.84 | 3.09/ 3.06 | .55/.46 | .81/.68 | 3.42/ 3.33 | .71/.71 | .84/.84 |
| | Social Media | 1 | 2.64 | .98 | .72 | 3.58 | .82 | .61 | - | - | - |
| | | 2 | 2.82 | .81 | .76 | 3.28 | .60 | .58 | - | - | - |
| | | 3 | 2.20 | .82 | .82 | 3.52 | .58 | .70 | - | - | - |
| | | 4 | 2.64/ 2.70 | .83/.78 | .73/.70 | - | - | - | 2.96/ 2.97 | .79/.71 | .75/.65 |
| | | 5 | 3.08/ 2.94 | .79/.79 | .88/.89 | 3.45/ 3.33 | .61/.63 | .83/.80 | 3.14/ 3.01 | .78/.71 | .88/.85 |
| Agreeableness | Offline | 1 | 3.82 | .71 | .44 | 3.05 | .72 | .53 | - | - | - |
| | | 2 | 3.79 | .65 | .69 | 3.20 | .59 | .68 | - | - | - |
| | | 3 | 3.99 | .64 | .73 | 3.25 | .59 | .76 | - | - | - |
| | | 4 | 3.89/ 3.78 | .68/.72 | .71/.74 | - | - | - | 3.88/ 3.73 | .78/.77 | .82/.79 |
| | | 5 | 3.81/ 3.79 | .61/.60 | .79/.81 | 3.16/ 3.23 | .53/.44 | .78/.66 | 3.93/ 3.84 | .64/.61 | .83/.81 |
| | Social Media | 1 | 3.57 | .78 | .49 | 2.80 | .86 | .64 | - | - | - |
| | | 2 | 3.61 | .72 | .71 | 2.94 | .76 | .78 | - | - | - |
| | | 3 | 3.73 | .68 | .73 | 2.78 | .74 | .81 | - | - | - |
| | | 4 | 3.60/ 3.52 | .69/.72 | .66/.67 | - | - | - | 3.73/ 3.66 | .76/.73 | .80/.77 |
| | | 5 | 3.64/ 3.60 | .61/.62 | .80/.80 | 2.75/ 2.64 | .77/.67 | .89/.87 | 3.69/ 3.67 | .68/.62 | .85/.83 |
| Neuroticism | Offline | 1 | 2.99 | .97 | .69 | 3.29 | .74 | .62 | - | - | - |
| | | 2 | 2.77 | .85 | .81 | 2.99 | .60 | .69 | - | - | - |
| | | 3 | 2.75 | .97 | .87 | 2.94 | .59 | .77 | - | - | - |
| | | 4 | 2.92/ 2.87 | .93/.89 | .83/.82 | - | - | - | 2.77/ 2.76 | .87/.85 | .83/.80 |

| | | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 5 | 3.07/ 3.15 | .86/.77 | .91/.88 | 3.19/ 3.24 | .63/.53 | .87/.78 | 2.83/ 2.77 | .79/.64 | .88/.80 |
| Social Media | 1 | 2.55 | .95 | .68 | 3.31 | .89 | .69 | - | - | - |
| | 2 | 2.53 | .81 | .76 | 3.08 | .74 | .76 | - | - | - |
| | 3 | 2.37 | .82 | .83 | 3.05 | .69 | .77 | - | - | - |
| | 4 | 2.60/ 2.55 | .85/.75 | .77/.71 | - | - | - | 2.47/ 2.48 | .76/.78 | .78/.77 |
| | 5 | 2.70/ 2.83 | .74/.75 | .84/.88 | 3.25/ 3.44 | .75/.77 | .88/.89 | 2.60/ 2.62 | .62/.66 | .82/.84 |

*Note*. $n = 535$ (Study 1). $n = 546$ (Study 2), $n = 262$ (Study 3); $n_{T1} = 254$, $n_{T2} = 218$ (Study 4); $n_{T1} = 115$, $n_{T2} = 66$ (Study 5). Values for time 1 are before the slash for Studies 4 and 5; Values for time 2 are after the slash.

**Table A4**

*Analysis of Variance Results for the Effects of Context, Target, and Trait on Perception (Studies 1–3)*

| Effect | Study 1 ($N$ = 535) | | | | Study 2 ($N$ = 546) | | | | Study 3 ($N$ = 262) | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | df | $F$ | $p$ | Cohen's $f$ | df | $F$ | $p$ | Cohen's $f$ | df | $F$ | $p$ | Cohen's $f$ |
| Context | 1 | 21.62 | < .001 | .05 | 1 | 89.71 | < .001 | .09 | 1 | 114.42 | < .001 | .15 |
| Target | 1 | 135.55 | < .001 | .11 | 1 | 151.49 | < .001 | .12 | 1 | 11.34 | < .001 | .05 |
| Trait | 4 | 64.32 | < .001 | .16 | 4 | 214.59 | < .001 | .28 | 4 | 175.96 | < .001 | .37 |
| Context × target | 1 | 211.10 | < .001 | .14 | 1 | 118.90 | < .001 | .10 | 1 | 105.41 | < .001 | .14 |
| Context × trait | 4 | 17.67 | < .001 | .08 | 4 | 8.12 | < .001 | .05 | 4 | 5.76 | < .001 | .07 |
| Target × trait | 4 | 283.49 | < .001 | .33 | 4 | 189.27 | < .001 | .26 | 4 | 256.87 | < .001 | .45 |
| Context × target × trait | **4** | **35.26** | **< .001** | **.12** | **4** | **30.41** | **< .001** | **.11** | **4** | **28.74** | **< .001** | **.15** |
| Residuals | 10664 | | | | 10880 | | | | 5180 | | | |

*Note*. Highest order significant effect is bolded.

**Table A5**

*Analysis of Variance Results for the Effects of Context, Target, and Trait on Perception (Studies 4–5)*

| Effect | Study 4 ($N$ = 254) | | | | Study 5 ($N$ = 88) | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | df | $F$ | $p$ | Cohen's $f$ | df | $F$ | $p$ | Cohen's $f$ |
| Context | 1 | 167.68 | < .001 | .18 | 1 | 35.47 | < .001 | .12 |
| Target | 1 | 5.15 | .023 | .03 | 2 | 47.79 | < .001 | .19 |
| Trait | 4 | 309.54 | < .001 | .50 | 4 | 89.22 | < .001 | .37 |
| Context × target | **1** | **5.88** | **.015** | **.03** | 2 | 10.00 | < .001 | .09 |
| Context × trait | **4** | **11.74** | **< .001** | **.10** | 4 | 3.04 | .016 | .07 |
| Target × trait | **4** | **7.88** | **< .001** | **.08** | 8 | 32.98 | < .001 | .32 |
| Context × target × trait | 4 | 1.02 | .393 | .03 | **8** | **3.43** | **< .001** | **.10** |
| Residuals | 5041 | | | | 2610 | | | |

*Note*. Highest order significant effect is bolded.